North and North East. The IPKF were seen as saviours, acting as a buffer between the Sri Lankan Army and various militant groups. The mandate of the IPKF was to disarm all the militant groups, including the LTTE, the most powerful of them all. Once this had been done, an interim council was to be formed, followed by the conduct of provincial elections. Relations soured, however, when seventeen LTTE cadres died while in custody of the Sri Lankan Army, for which the LTTE blamed the Indian Army and refused to cooperate further. Overnight, friends became enemies and the LTTE and the Indian Army got locked into mortal combat, with the local population also turning hostile. Initially, the IPKF was on the back foot, having been caught off-guard by this sudden turn of events. However, over the course of a year or so, by trial and hit, the IPKF managed to get the situation somewhat under control, restoring a semblance of law and order, at least in the major cities and townships. The jungles however, remained under the control of the LTTE, from where they would continue to launch attacks on our camps, ambush our patrols or otherwise disrupt our convoys, by planting improvised explosive devices (IED) on the roads. Watching from the sidelines was the Sri Lankan Army, who, through this unexpected turn of events, now had the IPKF doing their dirty work. That was the general situation when I landed up in Trincomalee in April 1989.

After leaving Veena and Isha behind at Fatehgarh, I went to Delhi to meet my in-laws, then to Pune to meet my parents, using the layover to also apply for separated family (SF) accommodation at Pune.[2] From there it was by train to Madras (now Chennai) and by Air Force courier, an AN-32 aircraft to Trincomalee. I was picked up at the airport and taken via the 4th Mile Junction, where the road bifurcated towards Batticaloa, to the Battalion HQ at Trincomalee

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